
Field Reconnaissance



**13th Legion
Texas State Militia**

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FOREWORD

13th Legion Publication (13LP) 3-1, *Field Reconnaissance*, is an abbreviated version the U.S. Army's Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP 3-20.98) and provides framework and tactical employment principles and techniques for reconnaissance elements of the Texas State Militia, mounted and dismounted.

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Introduction

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-1)

Reconnaissance is a mission to obtain, by visual observation or other detection methods, information about the activities and resources of an enemy or adversary, or to secure data concerning the meteorological, hydrographic, or geographic characteristics of a particular area.

The scout platoons seek to determine valuable information about enemy forces, terrain, and local populations. Successful reconnaissance enables the supported unit to seize, retain, and exploit the initiative, by identifying, creating, and capitalizing on opportunities discovered and reported by the platoon. A key component of reconnaissance is providing timely and accurate information, allowing maneuver commanders to generate options and make timely decisions, enabling the commander to maneuver to positions of advantage and concentrate combat power at the decisive point. Skillful reconnaissance operations allow the commander to shape the battlefield, ideally accepting or initiating combat at times and places of their choosing.

Senses

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-2)

A scout's primary tools for reconnaissance are the human senses. The platoon's equipment supplements and complements those senses. The following are some examples of what a scout must be able to determine about the enemy through the use of the human senses. See table below.

Table 3-1. Scout senses

<i>Sight (Looks for)</i> -Movement, sudden or unusual movement. (Day) -Lights, fires, or reflections. (Night) -Enemy personnel. -Enemy vehicles, aircraft, and unmanned aircraft system (UAS). -Smoke or dust. -Engine exhaust fumes. -Unusual movement of farm or wild animals. -Activity of the local populace. -Vehicle tracks. -Signs or evidence of enemy occupation. -Recently cut foliage or vegetation. -Muzzle flashes.	<i>Hearing (Listens for)</i> -Gunfire sounds (by type of weapon). -Running engines. -Track sounds. -Voices. -Metallic sounds. -Unusual calm or silence. -Dismounted movement through brush or woods. -Enemy UAS or aircraft. -Indicators of enemy radio interception or jamming.
<i>Touch (Feels)</i> -Warmth of coals. -Freshness of tracks. -Age of discarded food or trash.	<i>Smell</i> -Cooking food. -Vehicle exhaust. -Burning petroleum, oils, and lubricants (POL). -Age of discarded food or trash. -Human waste.

Fundamentals of Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-2)

There are seven fundamentals that govern the planning and execution of reconnaissance tasks.

1. Ensure Continuous Reconnaissance

Conduct continuous reconnaissance to gain as much information as possible about the AO and enemy. Continuous reconnaissance provides commanders with a constant flow of information. Continuous reconnaissance does not mean every available asset at full power, nonstop, continuously.

2. Do Not Keep Reconnaissance Assets in Reserve

Every pair of eyes makes a difference. Employ all available personnel in executing reconnaissance tasks.

3. Orient on the Reconnaissance Objective

The reconnaissance objective is an effect or expectation the commander is hoping to achieve, prevent, confirm or deny.

4. Report All Information Rapidly and Accurately

Scouts aid the commander in development of plans and rapid decision-making. Scouts must report all information exactly as they see it and as fast as possible. Never assume, distort, or exaggerate.

5. Retain Freedom of Maneuver

Tactical mobility and maneuver drive the success of reconnaissance tasks. Scouts change movement techniques and employ multiple assets by phase to make contact with the smallest possible element and avoid becoming decisively engaged.

6. Gain and Maintain Enemy Contact

Scouts gain and maintain contact with the enemy on terms and conditions of their choosing. Commanders and staffs plan for and integrate aerial and ground sensors and platforms assist scouts to gain contact with the enemy,

7. Develop the Situation Rapidly

Effective scouts understand how time impacts movement (friendly and enemy) and how timely information collection requirements impact the commander's decisions. Whether scouts encounter an obstacle or an enemy force, they must rapidly develop the situation in regards to composition, disposition, and activity, quickly, with minimum guidance from higher. Time is the scout's most precious resource and cannot be wasted.

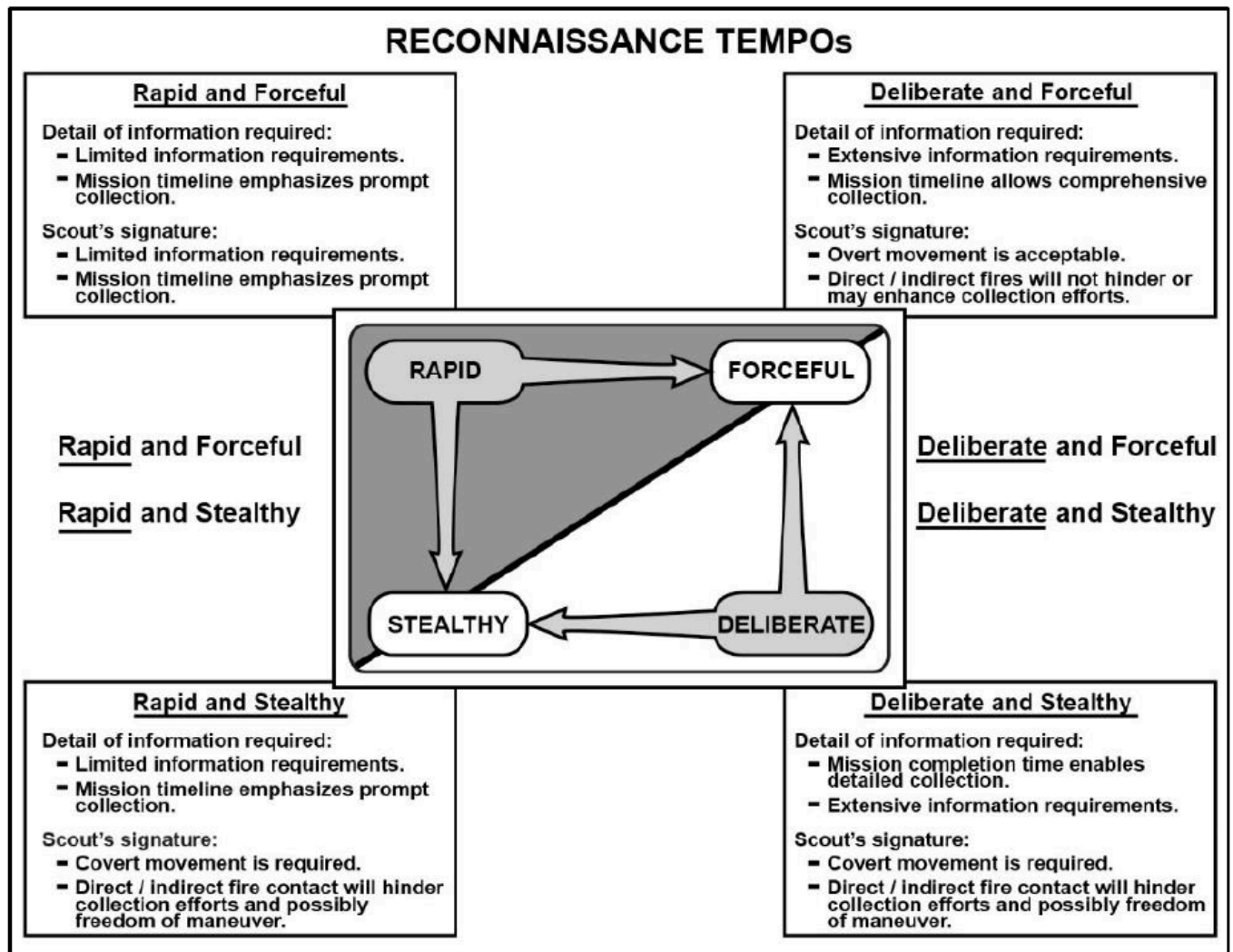
Tempo of Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-15)

Tempo refers to the level of detail and the level of covertness required by scouts to accomplish reconnaissance tasks. Four terms describe tempo: rapid, deliberate, stealthy, and forceful. Rapid and deliberate are levels of detail and are mutually exclusive meaning a scout cannot be rapid and deliberate at the same time. Stealthy and forceful are mutually exclusive levels of covertness meaning a scout cannot be stealthy and forceful at the same time. When the commander and/or staff issues reconnaissance guidance they express two of these words as tempo. Leaders must ensure everyone in the scout element

clearly understands what these words imply. For example, “Our tempo of reconnaissance will be stealthy and deliberate. I want to thoroughly check every culvert, ravine, ditch, and underpass for signs of enemy activity. Time is not as important as an exhaustive search.”

Reconnaissance tempo has four distinct terms and four possible combinations with it as displayed below.



Engagement and Disengagement Criteria

Engagement criteria are protocols that specify circumstances for initiation engagement with an enemy force. They can be either restrictive or permission but it is not sufficient to define engagement criteria using terms such as aggressive or discreet. Define engagement criteria using precise terms such as “three or fewer vehicles” or “squad size or smaller dismounted elements.”

Displacement Criteria

Displacement Criteria are triggers for planned withdrawal, passage of lines, or reconnaissance handoff between units. Displacement criteria conditions are either event-driven, time-driven, or threat driven. Once meeting the displacement criteria the scouts may transition to the next mission, phase, or task and are relieved from the responsibility of maintaining a form of contact with the enemy.

Graphic Control Measures

Assembly Area



(AA) An area a unit occupies to prepare for an operation.

Checkpoints



(CKP) A predetermined point on the ground used to control movement, tactical maneuver, and orientation.

Contact Point



A point on the terrain, easily identifiable, where two or more units are required to make contact.

Phase Lines



(PL) Line used for control and coordination of military operations, usually an easily identified feature in the operational area.

Line of Departure

(LD) A specific phase line which demarcates the beginning of a mission area.

Lateral Boundaries

(LB) Left and right boundaries of the mission area.

Limit of Advance

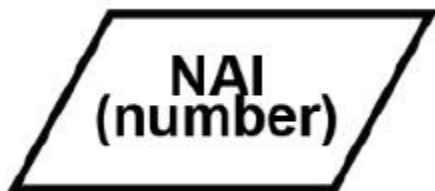
(LoA) A specific phase which demarcates the end of a mission area in which the scouting element will proceed no further.

Listening Post/Observation Post



(LP/OP) A position from which military observations are made, or fire directed and adjusted, and which possesses appropriate communication.

Named Areas of Interest



(NAI) A geospatial area or system node or link against which information that will satisfy a specific information requirement can be collected.

Route

RTE (name)

(RTE) The prescribed course to be traveled from a specific point of origin to a specific destination (will often include checkpoints).

Forms of Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-14)

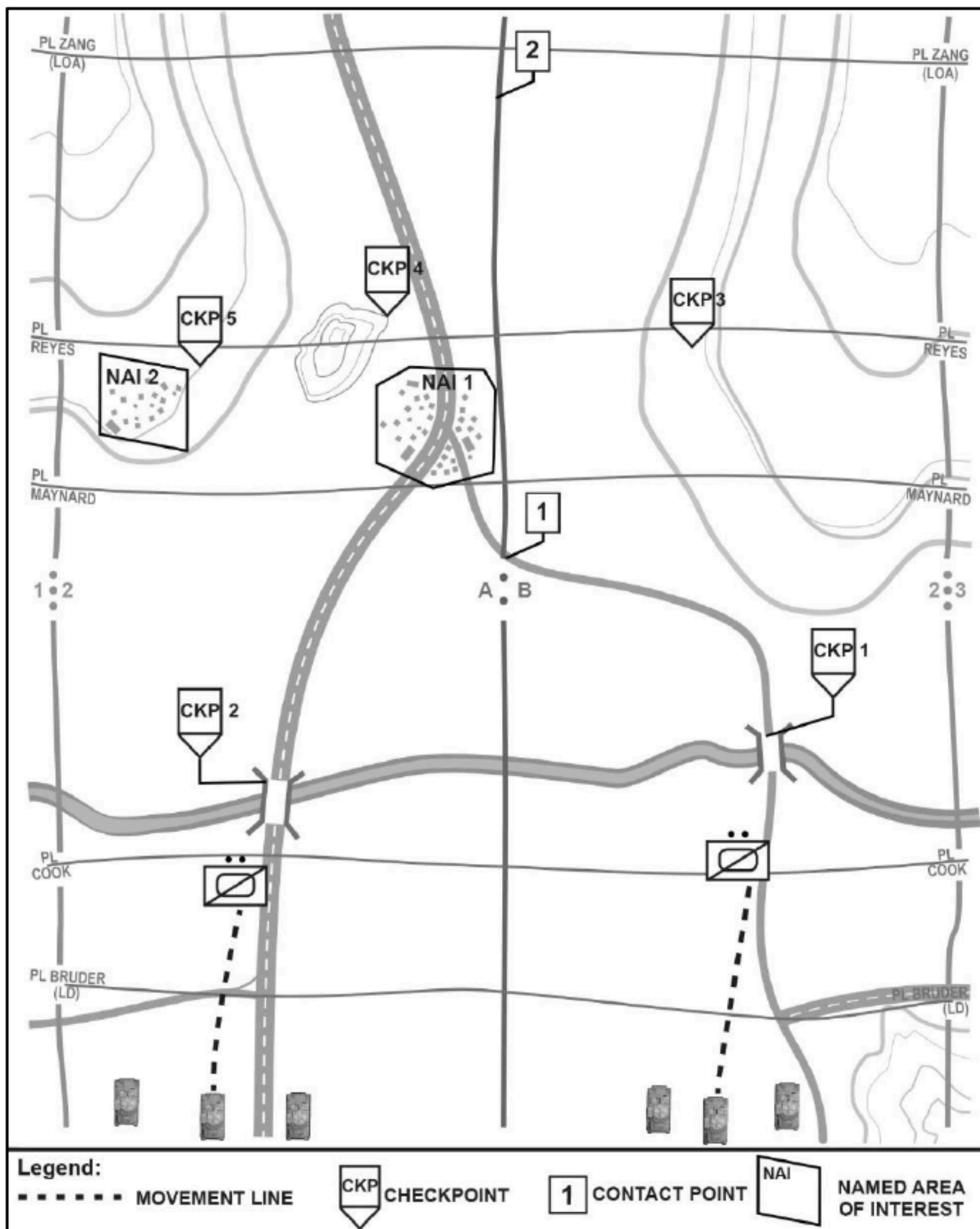
Zone Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-14)

Zone Reconnaissance is the directed effort to obtain detailed information concerning enemy, terrain, or civil considerations in accordance with the commander's intent. Scouts conduct a zone reconnaissance within a location delineated by a line of departure (LD), lateral boundaries (LB), and limit of advance (LOA).

Commanders direct scouts to conduct zone reconnaissance when they are uncertain of the composition and disposition of enemy forces in their AO, information concerning terrain is vague, or requiring information from or on the civilian population. In these cases, reconnaissance assets initially work over a broad area to develop the enemy situation. As they gain an understanding of enemy weaknesses, they then pull the main body to positions of tactical advantage.

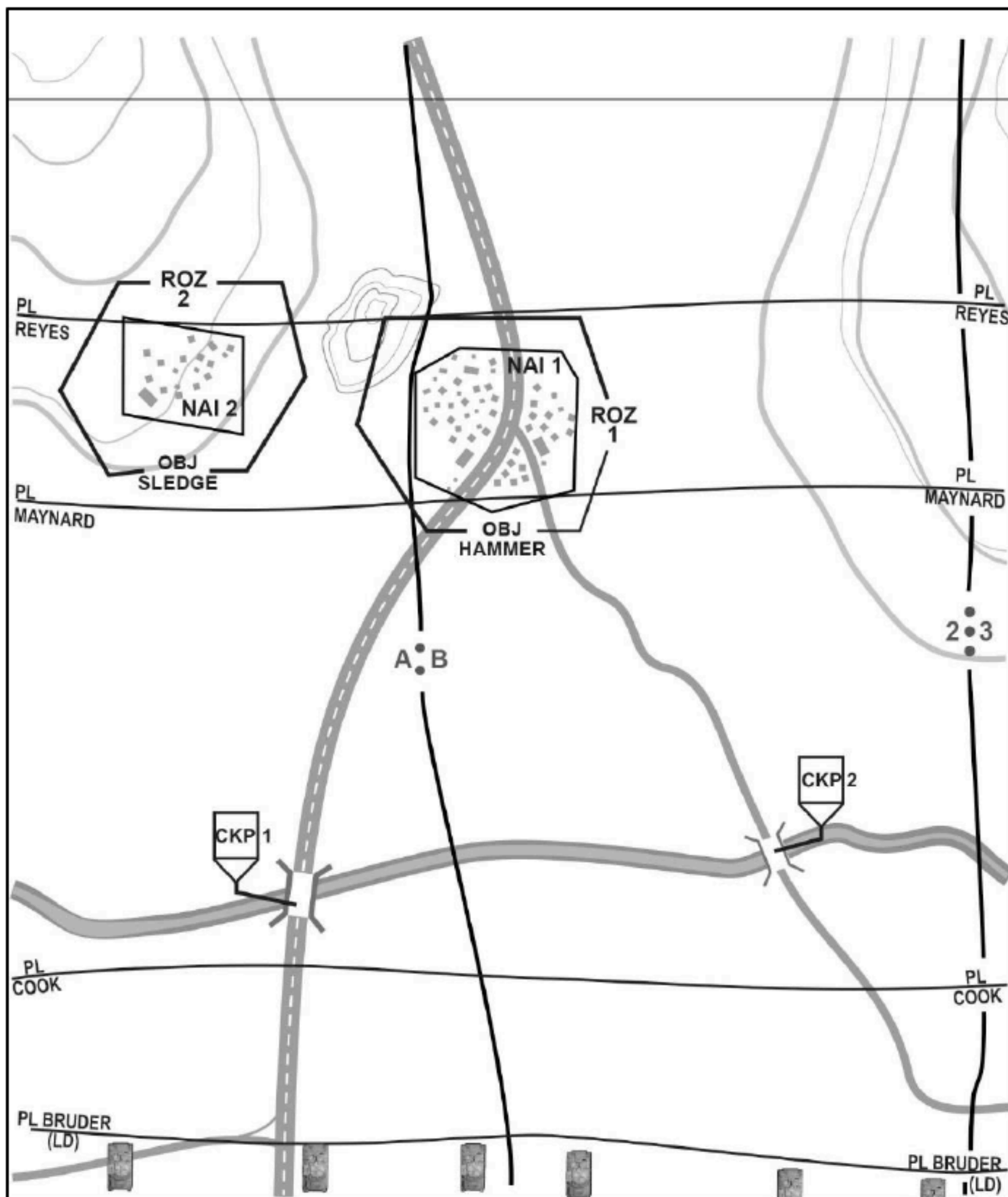
A zone reconnaissance is normally a deliberate, time-consuming process. It takes more time than any other reconnaissance mission, so the commander must plan for adequate time for the scout platoon to conduct the mission. A zone reconnaissance normally occurs over an extended distance and starts from a LD. However, when the reconnaissance objective is the enemy force, a commander may forgo a detailed reconnaissance of the zone and focus assets on those NAIs that would reveal enemy compositions and dispositions. The scout platoon cannot disregard terrain when focusing on the enemy. However, it may minimize its terrain reconnaissance to actions that influence an NAI.



Area Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-21)

An area reconnaissance is a form of reconnaissance that focuses on obtaining detailed information about the terrain, enemy, or civilian populations within a prescribed area. For example, a scout platoon may deploy to a prescribed area such as a town to gather information about the population, roads, bridges, market places, and other society and infrastructure. Area reconnaissance can often be employed in a zone reconnaissance for small towns, dead zones, and named areas of interest. The primary difference that identifies an area reconnaissance is the reduced size of the area boundaries compared to a zone reconnaissance.



Legend:

CKP CHECKPOINT
LD LINE OF DEPARTURE

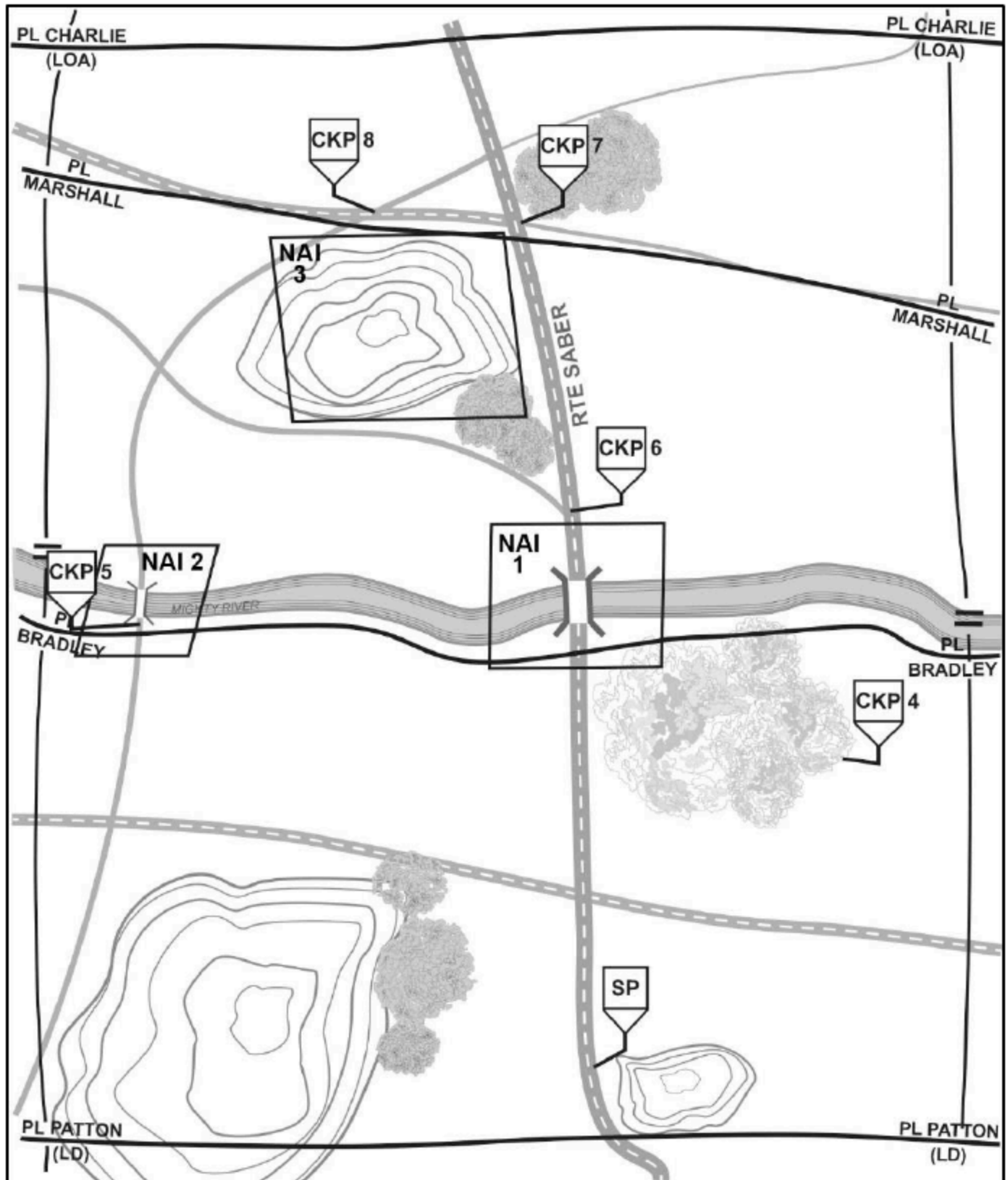
NAI NAMED AREA OF INTEREST
OBJ OBJECTIVE

PL PHASE LINE
ROZ RESTRICTED OPERATIONS ZONE

Route Reconnaissance

Scout Platoon Handbook (ATP -320-98, 3-27)

A route reconnaissance is a directed effort to obtain detailed information of a specified route and all terrain from which the enemy could influence movement along that route. A scout platoon conducts a route reconnaissance to answer questions for the commander about the presence and disposition of obstacles and enemy along a route and whether it will support the movement of friendly vehicles.



Legend:

CKP CHECKPOINT
LD LINE OF DEPARTURE
LOA LIMIT OF ADVANCE

NAI NAMED AREA OF INTEREST
PL PHASE LINE
RTE ROUTE

SP START POINT